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Newa indigenous health tips

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There are a few ancient remedies practised among the Newas in Nepal for getting rid of problems created by constipation. The present-day life style with less exercise, less fibre intake from processed foods, prepared using unhealthy oil including saturated/ unsaturated and refined oil are to blame for this kind of problem.

Some causes for constipation in the modern way of life are :

- Less physical activities, more stress, lack of sleep and certain medical issue such as Thyroid, loss of appetite, anal itching may lead to gas formation and ultimately ends with constipation.

- Consuming large quantity of dairy products such as milk, cheese, yoghurt, cream.

- Consuming less fibrous food as well as processed foods.

- Taking lots of medicine along with pain killer and Iron tablets.

- Dehydration, less fluid intake.

Even though constipation is not life threating, it is a kind of slow poison that may cause a big problem if not taken proper treatment in due course of time.

Hence, some very useful tips may be gleaned from the customs followed by Newa community from times immemorial.

1.Drinking a glass of warm water with a pinch of Hing (Asafoetida) is an easy practice widely followed. Hing (Asafoetida)is known for its laxative properties but care needs to be taken while using it directly. But it can be consumed without any precaution while used in preparing food, for it adds a better flavour. This is also not good for pregnant ladies as it might cause miscarriage. However, a paste made of pinch of Hing (Asafoetida) with water can be put into the navel.

2. Drinking a glass of rice water, that is, water collected after cleaning rice before cooking, is also effective.

3. Back and abdominal massage with oil and butter is a good relief for the gas blockage which is also a major cause for constipation.

4.Enema, injecting (inserting) clear water through anus, has also been in practice, though not as popular or easily executed as drinking a glass of rice water.

5.During prolonged constipation a pinch of Harital (Orpiment- Arsenic Sulphide) mixed in sweets is also said to be a quick relief. However, it might cause serious problem with gas formation inside the body causing diarrhoea, which is very difficult to control. So, proper care must be taken.

6.Consuming yoghurt regularly in the evening is also recommended to get a better relief.

7.Various mixtures of dry herbs and fruits of plant similar to Trishala churna (powder) are also effective.

8.Nowadays, there is a tendency to adopt Ayurvedic medicines and treatment, mixing it with indigenous forms of treatment: intake of food rich in fibre, green vegetables, and roots, blending food and yogurt, one teaspoon of fenugreek seed with lukewarm water before going to sleep, Dal soup made by mixing different beans and vegetable salad.

9. Some of the alternate therapy to get rid of constipation are as follows:

- Aromatherapy including oral oil intake - inhaling fumes of certain aromatic oil is also a kind of natural therapy along with oral intake of certain oil such as Castor oil.

- Acupuncture - stimulating certain points in the body can also help to get rid of constipation.

- Oral intake of lemon Juice and apple cider vinegar - Lemon Juice increases the alkaline level in the body which helps regulate the bowel movement. Consuming one teaspoon of lemon juice with a glass of warm water early morning can help as a stool softener. Apple cider vinegar contains water soluble fibre which is one of best treatments for constipation. It is recommended to take one teaspoonful of apple cider vinegar mixed in a glass of water twice or thrice a day for better bowel movement. (Warm water during winter and cold-water during summer)

- Lubrication and Massage therapy - Dousing oil laxative with a flow of water through anus and also inserting some oil through anus. Massage therapy and yoga pose can also help to promote bowel movement.

- Use of Triphala, the best Aryuvedic laxative in form of a powder prepared by mixing three different dry fruits of plant, Harroo (Terminalia Chebula), Barroo (Terminalia Bemerica) and Indian Gooseberry (Embolic Officinais). It is advised to take one teaspoon Triphala powder with lukewarm water before bed.

- Tea intake - varieties of organic and herbal tea are available in the market. One of the best is the Guduchi tea as well as slim tea.

Above all, eating healthy food, staying active, keeping away from stress, sleeping well and maintaining a happy outlook is the most basic of all remedies.